

Game Overview

This is a single-player roguelike strategy game inspired by the psychological tension and run-building of Balatro, but centered around predator/prey behavior, observation, adaptation, and resource management rather than cards.

The player controls an unknown apex predator moving through a dark forest at night. The creature is intentionally not a specific species. It is an adaptive predator that evolves through repeated hunts.

The game's visual style is minimalist and eerie:

- Nighttime forest setting
- Dark, high-contrast visuals
- Green-tinted "night vision" palette
- Strong silhouettes
- Minimal but expressive animation
- Atmosphere inspired by Inscryption and No, I'm Not A Human

The focus is on reading behavior rather than reacting to fast action.

Core Gameplay Loop

1. Enter encounter
2. Fight an animal
3. Gain blood and rewards
4. Choose path through forest
5. Find mutations, events, and resources
6. Face increasingly dangerous prey and predators
7. Survive as long as possible

mid-game runs should take roughly 20–40 minutes.

Core Resources

Health

Represents injuries.

Starting:

- 5 HP

If HP reaches 0:

- Run ends

Breath

Represents stamina, readiness, and composure.

Starting:

- 3/5 Breath

Maximum:

- 5 Breath

Breath is spent on actions.

Managing Breath is one of the most important strategic elements.

Blood

Primary currency.

Obtained only by killing enemies.

Used:

- Shops
- Events
- Instincts (I think one of the three adaptation choices introduced to you after 3 kills should be locked behind blood)
- Permanent upgrades (called adaptations) can only equip two for a run.

Combat Philosophy

Combat is not about damage racing.

Combat is about:

- Reading intentions
- Managing Breath
- Exploiting habits
- Creating favorable situations

The goal is for skilled players to consistently outperform inexperienced players even with identical builds.

Enemy Psychology System

Each enemy has an emotional state based on what their next move is going to be (thus the game always knows the move they'll use this turn as well as next, and the scheduled move can only change to a breathing move, i.e. rest, if breath is insufficient).

States are hidden.

Observe reveals them.

States:

Aggressive

Enemy is choosing offensive action next turn (or higher-level enemies feint).

Skittish

Enemy is choosing defensive action next turn (or higher-level enemies may trick this too).

Calm

Enemy behavior is difficult to predict. Could be doing anything, maybe using a special move (not an attack or defense move).

The player should interpret these clues.

The game should never explicitly say:

"It will attack next turn."

Instead:

"It seems aggressive."

Base Combat Actions For Player

Observe

Cost:

- 0 Breath

Gain:

- +2 Breath

Effect:

- Reveals enemy emotional state

Observe is intentionally risky.

Enemy still acts during the turn it is used.

Claw

Cost:

- 2 Breath

Damage:

- 2

Primary offensive action (other moves of all types may be unlocked by collecting move fragments during the game and unlocking the move between runs, more on that later).

Guard

Cost:

- 1 Breath

Effect:

- Reduce incoming damage by 1

Basic defensive action.

Example Enemy Deer Actions

Light Attack

Cost:

- 1 Breath

Damage:

- 1

Guard

Cost:

- 1 Breath

Reduces incoming damage by 1.

Dodge

Cost:

- 2 Breath

Avoids incoming attack.

Rest

Gain:

- +3 Breath

Used when exhausted (unable to use the scheduled move).

Hidden Information

Enemy Breath is hidden by default.

Players should infer exhaustion from behavior and animations.

Possible upgrades may reveal the exact Breath.

Progression Structure

The player starts hunting small prey.

As the run continues, enemies and modifiers get harder:

(smth like this, just concept)

Small Prey →

Large Prey →

Omnivores →

Predators →

Apex Predators →

Bosses

The ecosystem becomes increasingly dangerous and higher enemies should have some sort of strategy and maybe even mid-battle adjustment of enemies.

Enemy Examples

Early Game

Rabbit

Deer

Doe

Young Buck

Boar Piglet

Mid Game

Boar

Ram

Coyote
Wild Dog
Fox

Late Game

Wolf
Mountain Lion
Bear
Moose
Elk

Boss Examples

(All of these are just concepts right now, but these bosses, especially, should be more down-to-earth, especially at the beginning)

Ancient Stag
Alpha Wolf
Giant Bear
The White Predator
Forest Warden

Behavior Fragments

Enemies have a chance to drop behavior fragments.

Rare actions have rarer fragments.

Collect enough fragments to permanently unlock moves.

Example:

Dodge Fragment
Counter Fragment
Pounce Fragment
Ambush Fragment

This is the main move unlock system, but I want move selection and usage to always feel strategic, not just pure power.

Loadout System

Players bring:

2 Attack Moves
2 Defense Moves
2 Special Moves

Observe is always available

Advanced moves are unlocked permanently through fragments.

Example Future Moves

Attacks

Pounce
Heavy Claw
Bleed Strike
Ambush
Rend

Defenses

Dodge
Counter
Thick Hide
Intimidate
Retreat

Specials

Observe
Mark Prey
Howl
Feint
Predatory Focus
Stalk

Design Goals

The game should feel:

- Strategic
- Tense
- Atmospheric
- Readable
- Replayable
- Addicting

The player's primary skill should be understanding and exploiting behavior patterns.

The ideal feeling is:

"I knew what that creature was going to do."

rather than

"My numbers were bigger."

The game should create emergent stories through adaptation, prediction, and survival.

Other notes:

- There is a streak called focus, which increases attack. You gain +1 focus (up to 5) when dealing damage or mitigating damage (blocks or dodges). You lose all focus when hit directly or if you miss an attack or deal 0 damage with that attack.
- The more health an animal has, the more calm reads you'll get. The stronger an animal is, the more calm reads. Modifiers can also affect their aggression or skiddishness. Also if it's like a prey, it'll probably be skiddish first. I want the user to be able to bring SOME common sense into their fights.
- Higher-tier enemies will have faint, which gives them breath and makes them appear aggressive IF their state was calm, intimidate, which gives the next few calm reads a chance to appear aggressive, and other deceptive moves.
- Breath can overcharge but decreases by one if it is past maximum capacity at the end of a turn
- Make it so you can only have 3 instincts from each category, and they can be removed in an instincts menu during the game.
- Keep in mind the player can unlock different moves after the run by collecting behaviour fragments, instincts during the game (like run modifiers), and unlock permanently unlocked equipable adaptations between runs.
- Player heals 1 hp after every kill; all other healing needs to come from adaptations, items, and events. (Some late-game moves might also heal)

- Items can be found at special events and after encounters, as well as a special raccoon event where the raccoon shows you 3 items and u can buy them for blood. This encounter will be more common than the rest.
- Moves can be unlocked from move fragments that an animal has a rare chance to drop (rarer for rarer moves) for one of the animal's moves that the player doesn't have.
- Bosses have better fighting tactics and are harder.



OBSERVATION INSTINCTS

Instinct	Effect
Keen Eye	Observe reveals the enemy state with greater accuracy
Calm	Observe has a 30% chance to restore an extra breath.
Pattern Recognition	After observing an enemy twice, reveal its most likely action pattern. (less calm reads)
Sixth Sense	The 6th Observe in a round reveals the enemy's exact next action and gives an extra breath.
Heat Vision	Observe has a chance to reveal rest turns.
Hunter's Patience	If the first attack is after an observe it costs 1 less Breath.

Read the Wind	Correctly predicting an Aggressive enemy has a 25% chance to grant +1 Breath.
Perfect Read	If the first attack is after Observe it deals +1 damage.
Stalk	Consecutive Observes build +1 focus each.
Predator's Memory	Start each battle against a seen animal, knowing the enemy's initial state.
Behavioral Mapping	After observing an enemy 3 times, no more calm state reads.
Eye for Weakness	Observing an enemy on less than half health has a 50% chance of revealing its exact Breath.
False Calm	Calm enemies take +1 damage from a non-defended attack.
Watchful Silence	Gaining breath at max Breath grants +1 damage instead of overcharging.
Fear Aura	Enemies become Skittish slightly more often (more inclined to use defense moves).

Intimidation	Enemies have a higher chance to start battles Skittish (again, meaning they'e using a defense move).
Menacing Presence	Enemy state changes become easier to read (less calm reads).
Cornered Prey	Skittish enemies take +1 damage when successfully attacked.
Terror	Aggressive enemies lose 1 Breath when successfully defended.
Apex Presence	Enemies cannot become Calm after being successfully attacked or defended.
Predator's Stare	Observing slightly increases the chance an enemy becomes Skittish (use defensive move).
Dominance	Consecutive successful attacks increase Skittishness.
Dread	Wounded enemies become increasingly Skittish (more than the base thing that lower hp means more unstable states)

ATTACK INSTINCTS

Instinct	Effect
Frenzy	Consecutive attacks gain +1 damage.
Ambush	First attack each battle deals +1 damage.
Blood Scent	Killing enemies grants +2 extra Blood.
Savage Claws	Blocked attacks have a 10% deal of full damage.
Apex Predator	attacking a resting animal +1 attack damage.
Executioner	Deal +1 damage to enemies at half health. (Or if there is no exact half health then the number below that)
Relentless	if the enemy dodges an attack, a 25% restores 1 Breath.
Hidden Predator	Attacks after 2 non-attack turns deal +1 damage.

Shadow Hunter	Observing has a 50% chance of making ur next move count as an ambush move(the first move of the game)
Sudden Violence	First attack costs 1 less Breath.
Fatal Opening	Enemies above 75% HP have a 50% chance to take +2 damage.
Ruthless Pursuit	Attacking an enemy with 1 or less breath restores 1 Breath.
Bone Breaker	When ur opponent reaches below 25% health for the first time they lose 1 breath
Momentum	Having 3 or more focus increases ur attack by +1
Lethal Precision	When u hit a successful attack on ur opponent 2 times or more in a row ur next attack has a 20% chance to do +3 damage
Predator's Hunger	Gain 1 HP after every kill.
Crushing Pressure	Consecutive successful attacks drain 1 enemy Breath.

Winded Prey	Exhausted enemies become more predictable.
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DEFENSE INSTINCTS

Instinct	Effect
Thick Hide	+1 Health
Resilience	Successfully mitigating damage has a 30% chance to restore 1 Breath.
Counter Reflex	Successfully mitigating damage has a 30% chance to deal 1 damage.
Adaptive Skin	Negative weather modifiers are less severe.
Last Stand	Gain 1 Breath when below half HP.
Unyielding	Successfully mitigating damage grants +1 damage next attack.

Iron Nerves	Gain 1 Breath whenever you FULLY mitigate damage.
Retaliation	Attack after a successful damage mitigation costs 1 less Breath.
Predator's Trap	Observing an Aggressive enemy has a 50% chance to make defense moves cost 1 less breath.
Defensive Posture	Consecutive defense moves restore 1 Breath.
Endurance	Gain +1 max Breath.
Survival Drive	Surviving a hit at 1 HP restores 2 Breath.
Evasive Reflexes	Mitigating all damage of an enemy's attack makes them lose 1 Breath.
Toughened Bones	Enemy attacks deal -1 Breath damage effects. (for later game with more advanced enemies)



SURVIVAL INSTINCTS

Instinct	Effect
Scavenger	Carcasses provide more Blood.
Fresh Tracks	Animal Trails appear more often.
Forager	Berry events provide stronger rewards.
Deep Lungs	+1 max Breath.
Efficient Metabolism	Healing events and items restore 1 more HP.
Lucky Find	Items appear more often.
Carrion Feeder	Gain more HP from Carcass events.
Trailblazer	Reveal one path exactly at every fork.
Resourceful	10% chance to gain an item at the start of an encounter
Water Sense	Watering Holes appear more frequently.

Bone Collector	Gain Blood whenever you find Behavior Fragments.
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**Items won't have categories in-game;
here, it's just to sort them:**

Observation Items (Single Use)

Owl Eye

Reveal the enemy's exact next action.

Crow Feather

+1 breath.

Echo Stone

The foe's breath echoes through the field. Reveal enemy Breath for the rest of the battle.

Moonstone

The next three observes flawlessly reveal the next emotional states (no calm).

Firefly Jar

Reveal their state without observing

Attack Items (Single Use)

Eagle Eye

Next attack cannot be dodged.

Sharp Stone

Next attack deals +2 damage.

Broken Antler

Next attack ignores defense (can still be dodged).

Predator Claw

Use two attacks this turn.

Dried Meat

Restore 2 Breath immediately.

Bloodroot

Deal 1 damage instantly.



Defense Items (Single Use)

Snake Skin

-1 damage to the next enemy attack.

Bone Charm

50% chance to negate all damage this turn.

Fox Tail

Defense moves cost 1 less breath this turn and next.

Moss Bundle

Remove a battle modifier from yourself.

Spider Egg Sac

Enemy loses 1 Breath.



Exhaustion Items (Single Use)

Leech Cluster

Steal 1 Breath and 1 health.

Hollow Tooth

Gain double blood from this encounter.

Amber Sap

Enemy cannot Rest this turn.

Frozen Berry

Enemy's action this turn costs +1 Breath.

Bone Needle

Enemy loses 1 max Breath for rest of battle.



Fear Items (Single Use)

Raven Skull

Force enemy into a Skittish state (defensive move next turn).

Thorn Crown

Force enemy into an Aggressive state (attacking move next turn, or feint).

White Feather

Force enemy into a Calm state and remove one of their battle modifiers if applicable.

Hunter's Trinket

Lock enemy state for one turn.

Rare Items (Single Use, more rare)

Black Mushroom

Gain a random instinct just for this battle.

Crystal Pebble

Duplicate an instinct just for this battle.

Moonflower

Transform one instinct into a random rare instinct just for this battle.

Stag Horn

Choose one of three random instincts (instinct limits still apply).

Ancient Acorn

Heal to full.

Spirit Fang

Instantly deal 4 damage to a prey enemy.

Lunar Seed

Gain 2 random items.

Heartwood Fragment

Duplicate an item.

Legendary Single-Use Items (most rare)

These should make players go:

"I'm saving this for the boss."

Eclipse Bloom

Reveal every enemy state for the battle.

Apex Fang

Next attack deals triple damage.

Forest Heart

Fully restore HP and Breath.

Dream Fruit

Duplicate any instinct you own (instinct limits still apply).

Blood Moon Petal

Gain 5 times Blood from this battle.

Spirit Totem

Can't be killed this turn.



SPECIAL EVENTS

Watering Hole

Background

Moonlit pond.

Rewards

Choose one:

- Restore all Breath.
 - Heal 2 HP.
 - Gain temporary Observation instinct.
-

Carcass

Background

Half-eaten deer corpse.

Rewards

Choose one:

- Gain Blood.
 - Gain Blood + lose Breath.
 - Gain Item.
-

Hollow Log

Background

Rotting fallen tree.

Rewards

- Random Item.
 - Small Blood stash.
 - Rare chance for Fragment.
-

Berry Thicket

Background

Dense bushes.

Rewards

Choose one:

- Heal HP.
 - Gain Breath.
 - Risk poisonous berries for larger reward.
-

Animal Trail

Background

Narrow path through forest.

Rewards

Easy battle for -common item

Medium battle for- rare item

Hard battle (boss level enemy) for-legendary item

Nesting Grounds

Background

Eggs and feathers.

Rewards

Choose one:

- Breath max
 - Fragment chance.
 - Blood.
-

Fog Clearing

Background

Dense fog opening.

Rewards

- Remove all modifiers for next 3 rounds.
 - Could stumble upon enemy for item reward
-

Ancient Oak

Background

Massive ancient tree.

Rewards

Choose 1 of 3 Instincts.

Abandoned Den

Background

Old predator shelter.

Rewards

Choose one:

- Blood.
 - Item.
 - Breath.
-



RARE EVENTS

Tree of Life

Background

Gigantic glowing tree.

Rewards

Choose one:

- Rare Instinct.
 - Heal fully.
 - Duplicate an instinct.
-

Dream Pool

Background

Perfectly reflective water.

Rewards

Choose one:

- Duplicate item.
 - Duplicate instinct.
 - Remove one instinct and gain two new options. (one item, one instinct)
-

Eclipse Clearing

Background

Moon blocked by darkness.

Rewards

Choose one:

- instinct.

- Next 3 battles have a dangerous modifiers + huge reward.
-

Albino Stag

Background

White stag watching silently.

Rewards

Choose one:

- Rare Fragment.
 - Rare Item.
 - Large Blood reward.
-

Bone Field

Background

Field of animal skeletons.

Rewards

Choose one:

- Blood reward.
 - Rare Item.
 - Gain better future items, better rarity.
-

Hunter's Camp

Background

Abandoned human campsite.

Rewards

Choose one:

- Unique Item.
 - Blood cache.
-

Heartwood Shrine

Background

Ancient roots wrapped around stone.

Rewards

Choose one:

- Trade instincts.
 - Heal
-

Moonlit Altar

Background

Stone altar under full moon.

Rewards

Choose one:

- Sacrifice HP for Blood.
 - Sacrifice Blood for rare instinct.
 - Sacrifice instinct for a legendary item.
-

Blood Spring

Background

Red-tinted water bubbling from the ground.

Rewards

Choose one:

- Gain Blood.
 - Gain more Blood and more modifiers for next 2 rounds.
 - Gain rare item.
-

EVENTS THAT CREATE STORIES

These are the ones I'd prioritize because players remember them.

Wounded Wolf

Fight weakened predator for rare rewards.

Trapped Animal

Free it for future reward or eat it now.

Strange Tracks

Follow unknown creature into dangerous encounter.

Whispering Grove

Trade an instinct for a random one.

Spirit Crossing

Answer a choice event with unknown outcomes.

Sleeping Bear

Sneak past, steal from, or fight.

Moon Beast Tracks

Begin a hidden boss path.

Lost Cub

Help it for future rewards or ignore it.

Dying Predator

Learn a behavior fragment from it.

The Watching Eyes

Something observes you from the darkness for multiple encounters.

Those last 10 are the ones that start giving the game personality. Players won't remember "Berry Thicket #43." They'll remember:

"I stole food from a sleeping bear, got a legendary item, then died three fights later because the bear started hunting me."

That's the kind of stuff that turns a solid roguelike into one people tell stories about.

Battle modifiers are actually where you can get a lot of your run variety from. I'd split them into categories:

- **Environmental** (changes battlefield conditions)
- **Enemy Traits** (changes how enemies behave)
- **Predator Conditions** (affects the player)
- **Mutators** (changes fundamental rules)

That way a fight isn't just:

Deer #27

It's:

Crazed Deer during a Thunderstorm with Parasites.



Environmental Modifiers

Dense Fog

Observe rarley reveals information.

Icon: Fog cloud

Heavy Rain

All Breath restoration is reduced by 1.

Icon: Rain drops

Cold Snap

First Breath spent each turn costs an additional Breath.

Icon: Snowflake

Drought

Less likely for next special event until it goes away.

Icon: Cracked earth

Darkness

Enemy Breath cannot be revealed.

Icon: Crescent moon

Blood Moon

Aggressive behaviors become more common.

Icon: Red moon

Thunderstorm

Enemy emotional states shift more frequently.

Icon: Lightning bolt

Wildfire Smoke

Observations are less accurate.

Icon: Smoke plume



Enemy Behavior Modifiers

Crazed-

Enemy is much more aggressive.

Icon: Glowing eyes

Territorial

Enemy deals +1 damage when attacked repeatedly.

Icon: Claw marks

More Skittish

Enemy dodges more often.

Icon: Running deer

More Defensive

Enemy guards more often.

Icon: Shield

Opportunistic

Enemy attacks more when you are low on Breath.

Icon: Fang

Patient Hunter

Enemy waits and attacks in bursts.

Icon: Eye

Frenzied

Enemy gains damage after successful attacks.

Icon: Blood splash

Unpredictable

Emotional state changes constantly.

Icon: Question mark



Predator Conditions

These affect the player.

Diseased

Maximum health reduced by 1.

Icon: Green skull

Parasites

Lose 1 Breath at start of battle.

Icon: Worm

Starving

Begin battles with reduced Breath.

Icon: Rib cage

Wounded

Start battle missing 1 HP.

Icon: Blood droplet

Exhausted

Breath restoration effects are weaker.

Icon: Broken lung

Shaken

Focus has a chance 20% to decrease every turn

Icon: Cracked eye

Rule-Changing Modifiers- rare

These are the fun ones.

Endless Night

20% less special encounters appear until boss.

Icon: Black moon

Predator Territory

All enemies are stronger but rewards improve for the next 3 battles

Icon: Pawprint

Migration

Enemy state change more rapidly for the next 3 battles

Icon: Footprints

Primeval Forest

Rare enemies appear more frequently.

Icon: Ancient tree

Famine

Blood and breath rewards increase.
Healing rewards decrease. For 3 battles

Icon: Empty bone

Blight

More modifiers appear throughout the run. For 3 battles

Icon: Dead leaf

Lunar Madness

All creatures become more aggressive. For 3 rounds

Icon: Red eye

Survival of the Fittest

Enemies have more HP.

Rewards are better. For 3 rounds

Icon: Crown
